

THE GOSPEL OF THE HONEYBUN

The Third Installation of the Baji'i Gospels

Being the account of Amanda Haeberlin, called the OG Rabbi; of Caleb Juetten; of the disturbance at Chevy's Lounge; and of the pastry by which a sermon was answered.

FIRST DRAFT

I. Before There Were Rabbis

1. Four thousand and twenty-six years before the present age, the Jillow made a promise to the faithful.
2. They would have rabbis.
3. They would have synagogues.
4. They would have a Holy Land.
5. History, as it often does, became complicated.
6. The promises were delayed, misplaced, appropriated, reinterpreted, argued over, and eventually buried beneath enough centuries that ordinary people forgot they had ever been made.
7. The Jillow did not forget.
8. The Jillow is capable of forgetting many things, particularly when sleeping, but apparently not contractual obligations.
9. And so, before Gretta Stark became the rabbi of Ji's formative years, before the Company of Questions rode buses across Missouri, before Tim and AJ began compiling the histories, there had already appeared another rabbi.
10. Her name was Amanda Haeberlin.
11. Later Baji'i scholars called her the OG Rabbi.
12. They did this partly because she came first and partly because no title more dignified ever survived popular usage.
13. Amanda did not arrive in robes.
14. She did not descend from a mountain.
15. No pillar of fire announced her.
16. She appeared at Chevy's Lounge.
17. This was, in retrospect, a more appropriate beginning.

II. Chevy's Lounge

1. Chevy's Lounge was the sort of place where the evening could begin with somebody saying he was only staying for one drink and end with three people attempting to reconstruct what had happened from conflicting testimony.
2. The lights were dim enough to improve everyone slightly.
3. The music was loud enough to make bad ideas difficult to interrupt.
4. The floor possessed a permanent uncertainty of texture.
5. And among the patrons on the night remembered by Baji'ism was Caleb Juetten.
6. Caleb was a friend of Ji Yong Ni.
7. He was known for drinking.
8. He was also known for opinions that became neither wiser nor quieter as the drinking continued.
9. His friends had learned that there were several stages to an evening with Caleb.
10. First came sociability.
11. Then confidence.
12. Then unnecessary confidence.
13. Then statements that caused everyone nearby to decide whether correcting him was worth the effort.
14. On this night he passed through the stages efficiently.
15. A disagreement began at one end of the room.
16. No surviving account agrees on what caused it.
17. This is usually evidence that the cause was stupid.
18. One man claimed another had bumped him.
19. Another claimed someone had insulted somebody's girlfriend.
20. Caleb later claimed he had been 'basically not involved,' which the rabbis regard as strong evidence that he was involved.
21. Voices rose.
22. Chairs moved.
23. Someone knocked over a drink.

24. And once a drink has been knocked over in anger, civilization is already negotiating from a weakened position.

III. Amanda Haeberlin

1. Amanda had not come to Chevy's Lounge intending to found anything.
2. She had come, according to the oldest tradition, because somebody had asked her to come out and she had made the mistake of saying yes.
3. She watched the argument grow.
4. Amanda was often one of the loudest people in the room.
5. This was useful, because nearly everyone causing the problem was also loud.
6. She had the kind of authority that could encourage a room at full volume and correct it just as loudly when necessary.
7. When the first shove occurred, she stood.
8. 'Enough.'
9. Nobody listened.
10. This did not discourage her so much as offend her.
11. She stepped nearer.
12. 'You are grown men fighting in a bar over something none of you are going to remember tomorrow.'
13. One of the men insisted that he would remember.
14. Amanda told him this did not improve the situation.
15. Caleb laughed.
16. She turned toward him.
17. 'And you. You are not helping.'
18. Caleb, who had been enjoying the rare privilege of watching someone else receive criticism, was surprised to find himself included.
19. 'I didn't do anything.'
20. Amanda looked at the room around him.
21. 'I don't believe you.'
22. The Baji'i rabbis consider this the first recorded exercise of rabbinical discernment.

IV. The Way of the Jillow

1. Amanda did not know that she was about to preach.
2. The best sermons sometimes begin as irritation.
3. She told them to sit down.
4. Some did.
5. Some remained standing but became embarrassed enough to stop advancing.
6. Caleb leaned against something that was not designed to support him.
7. Amanda looked upon the room and said, 'You all have a choice about what happens next.'
8. The words were ordinary.
9. The Jillow entered them anyway.
10. She told them that a person could spend his whole life feeding whatever was worst in him and then act surprised when the worst part became strong.
11. Or he could interrupt himself.
12. He could stop.
13. He could decide that not every insult required an answer, not every anger required an audience, and not every stupid moment had to become a worse one.
14. 'Turn away from this,' she said.
15. Then, without understanding why the phrase came to her, she added:
16. 'Turn to the way of the Jillow.'
17. The room became quiet.
18. This was partly because the words carried divine weight.
19. It was partly because nobody knew what a Jillow was.
20. Amanda did not entirely know either.
21. Somewhere beyond the visible world, the two faces of the sacred pillow regarded one another.
22. Ji Yong inclined toward the sermon.
23. Ji Song, according to later commentary, waited to see what Caleb would do.
24. He did not have to wait long.

V. The Honeybun

1. Caleb stared at Amanda.
2. Amanda stared back.
3. On a nearby table rested a packaged honeybun.
4. Its owner has never been identified.
5. This anonymity is one of the minor mysteries of the faith.
6. Caleb picked it up.
7. There was precedent.
8. Caleb had, on prior occasions, been known to throw honeybuns at people he believed to be homeless.
9. Why he possessed this habit is beyond the scope of theology.
10. Why he mistook Amanda for a homeless person is equally uncertain.
11. Perhaps it was the lighting.
12. Perhaps it was the alcohol.
13. Perhaps Ji Song simply wished to see what would happen.
14. Caleb drew back his arm.
15. One witness said, 'Caleb, don't.'
16. This instruction arrived at the precise moment when Caleb had become psychologically incapable of following it.
17. The honeybun flew.
18. It crossed the space between foolishness and history.
19. It struck Amanda.
20. Silence followed.
21. Not ordinary silence.
22. The kind of silence in which every person present instantly understands that the evening has changed categories.
23. Caleb lowered his hand.
24. 'Oh.'

25. Amanda looked down at the honeybun.

26. She looked back at Caleb.

27. And the first rabbi of Baji'ism said:

28. 'Are you serious?'

29. Thus was the sermon concluded.

VI. The Sign of the Pastry

1. Later generations embellished the Honeybun.
2. Some claimed it stopped in midair before striking Amanda.
3. This is false.
4. Some claimed it burst into flame.
5. This is also false and would have improved the story in ways unsupported by tradition.
6. One sect briefly taught that the honeybun had no calories.
7. This sect was condemned for obvious reasons.
8. The miracle was not in the pastry.
9. The miracle was what happened after.
10. Nobody resumed the fight.
11. The ridiculousness of the act had broken the anger in the room.
12. Men who seconds earlier had been preparing to hit one another were now staring at Caleb as though he had personally embarrassed the entire species.
13. One began laughing.
14. Another followed.
15. Even the man who had first been shoved forgot, temporarily, that he had intended to avenge himself.
16. Amanda did not laugh immediately.
17. She possessed standards.
18. But eventually the absurdity overcame her too.
19. The room settled.
20. Drinks were replaced.
21. Chairs were returned.
22. Somebody gave Amanda a napkin.
23. Caleb offered an apology whose sincerity exceeded its eloquence.
24. And so peace came to Chevy's Lounge not by force, nor by argument, but because one man threw a honeybun at exactly the wrong person.

25. Baji'i theology does not recommend this method.
26. It merely records that the Jillow is willing to work with poor materials.

VII. Caleb Before the Wheel

1. When Ji later heard the story, he found the honeybun portion significantly more interesting than the sermon.
2. Tim attempted to explain that the sermon was probably theologically important.
3. Ji said, 'Yeah but he threw a honeybun at her.'
4. AJ agreed that this was difficult to move past.
5. Evan wanted to know why Caleb had possessed immediate access to a honeybun.
6. No answer satisfied him.
7. Caleb defended himself by insisting that, at the time, his understanding of the situation had been different.
8. 'Different how?' Tim asked.
9. Caleb declined to elaborate.
10. Ji laughed for longer than the story required.
11. Yet when the laughter faded, the question of karma remained.
12. Did throwing the honeybun lower Caleb's odds on the Wheel?
13. Almost certainly.
14. Did his apology restore them?
15. Somewhat.
16. By how much?
17. Nobody knew.
18. The Wheel does not publish an itemized statement.
19. This bothered Tim.
20. It did not bother Ji.
21. 'Just don't throw stuff at rabbis,' Ji said.
22. Tim pointed out that this would make a useful commandment.
23. Ji refused.
24. There were already three.

25. Caleb asked whether throwing things at non-rabbis was therefore permitted.

26. Everyone told him no.

27. And this is why Baji'ism distinguishes between that which is technically uncommanded and that which a reasonable person should already know.

VIII. The OG Rabbi

1. Amanda did not become a rabbi because she had memorized doctrine.
2. At the time there was hardly any doctrine available to memorize.
3. She became a rabbi because she performed the oldest work of the office before the office had been restored.
4. She entered disorder and asked people to choose differently.
5. She spoke of the Jillow before she understood why.
6. She called people away from the worst version of themselves.
7. And when the response to her preaching was a pastry to the body, she remained standing.
8. Gretta Stark would later become the rabbi of formation: the teacher who shaped Ji and his companions through expectation, patience, and the occasional demand that Ji hustle.
9. Amanda was something different.
10. She was the rabbi of interruption.
11. She appeared in the middle of a bad decision and said, in effect, that the next decision did not have to be worse.
12. This became one of the quieter teachings of Baji'ism.
13. Karma is not merely the sum of grand deeds.
14. It changes in rooms like Chevy's Lounge.
15. It changes in the second between anger and action.
16. It changes when a person has already behaved badly and must decide whether to continue.
17. The Wheel is influenced not only by who a person has been, but by what he does next.
18. Caleb had thrown the honeybun.
19. He could not unthrow it.
20. But he could stop throwing things.
21. Progress, the rabbis observed, sometimes begins embarrassingly low.

IX. The Delayed Promise

1. News of the event did not spread across nations.
2. No crowds gathered outside Chevy's Lounge.
3. No synagogue was constructed the following morning.
4. The ancient Holy Land remained unreclaimed.
5. The promised restoration had begun almost invisibly.
6. This suited Baji'ism.
7. Public worship was forbidden.
8. Its history therefore preferred side doors.
9. A rabbi appeared without knowing she was a rabbi.
10. A sermon occurred in a bar without being advertised as a sermon.
11. A sacred sign was made from a snack nobody could account for.
12. Years later Ji Yong Ni would be recognized as the Divine Connection Between Heaven & Earth.
13. Greta Stark would mentor him.
14. Tim and AJ would begin preserving stories.
15. Evan and the other companions would become part of those stories whether they had intended to or not.
16. But Amanda's appearance came as evidence that the Jillow had begun moving before the prophet's generation fully understood what was being restored.
17. The old promise had not been abandoned.
18. It had merely been running late.
19. Ji, upon hearing this interpretation, objected to the comparison.
20. He said there was a difference between being four thousand years late and being a few minutes late.
21. Greta, when informed of this defense, was unmoved.

X. The Teaching of the Honeybun

1. The faithful sometimes ask why this story deserves preservation.
2. Surely there were nobler moments.
3. Surely a religion should remember visions, sacrifices, revelations, and victories rather than an intoxicated man throwing packaged pastry at a woman who had just attempted to stop a bar fight.
4. The rabbis answer that this objection misunderstands the religion.
5. The Jillow has two sides.
6. Good and evil, wisdom and stupidity, order and chaos exist close enough to touch.
7. Human beings rarely encounter these things in pure form.
8. They encounter them mixed together in themselves.
9. A person can say something wise and then do something foolish.
10. A fool can accidentally end a fight.
11. A humiliating moment can become the point at which a person finally sees himself clearly.
12. A bar can become, briefly and without violating the First Commandment, a place of revelation.
13. And a honeybun can cross a room as an act of stupidity and land in scripture.
14. Therefore the Gospel of the Honeybun teaches:
15. When anger rises, interrupt it.
16. When foolishness has already occurred, do not make loyalty to your foolishness into a second sin.
17. When another person offers you a way out of becoming worse, take it.
18. And when Caleb is holding a honeybun, pay attention.
19. Amanda Haeberlin was remembered as the OG Rabbi.
20. Caleb Juetten was remembered as the man who threw the honeybun.
21. The inequality of these legacies is considered just.
22. Baji.

Scribal Note

The Chevy's Lounge incident, Amanda Haeberlin's status as the OG rabbi, Caleb Juetter's presence and reputation, and the honeybun tradition come from the established Baji'i account. The surrounding scene, dialogue, characterization, the concept of Amanda as the 'rabbi of interruption,' and the fuller theological interpretation are narrative expansions in the style of the preceding gospels. This installment deliberately leaves the invisible baboons, the Taliban conflict, the promised Holy Land itself, Marcia Ann Humphreys, and the Floriculture national championship substantially untouched for later stories.